

Recently and lately

Teaching guide

Choose a tense that fits the event, not just the adverb.

Understand the distinction

Recently means a short time ago or during the recent past. It can describe one finished event with the past simple: I recently bought a bike. It also occurs with the present perfect: I have recently changed jobs.

Lately usually describes recent states or repeated activity, often with the present perfect: I have been busy lately; I have been cycling lately. It is less usual for a single finished event. Neither word requires the present perfect continuous, and neither guarantees that an activity will continue.

Compare the patterns

ONE EVENT

I recently visited a friend.

Past simple fits a finished visit.

RECENT STATE

I have been tired lately.

Been + adjective describes a state.

REPEATED ACTIVITY

I have been walking more lately.

The continuous form highlights activity.

Read each example. Explain what the highlighted choice means in context. Then cover the example and say a similar sentence.

Check your understanding

Write before looking at the answers. The guide gives a model answer and explains the choice. Other wording can be correct.

1. Choose for a single visit: I visited Rome ____ . (recently / lately)

2. Is I have been busy lately a present perfect continuous verb?

3. Does I have been running lately guarantee future running?

Use it in your own life

Write one recent event and one recent habit or state.

Self-check

Does your sentence express your intended meaning? Does its form follow the relevant pattern? Can a reader understand the context?

Try again

After checking the explanation, revise your sentence. Say it aloud or use it in a short conversation.

Answers and explanation

1. recently

Recently readily refers to a single past event.

2. No. It is present perfect be followed by an adjective.

The continuous form needs an -ing main verb.

3. No. It describes recent activity.

Future continuation needs more context.

One possible response

I recently joined a class. I have been studying more lately.

This is a model, not the only acceptable answer. Assess meaning, grammar, and context together.

Continue learning

Web lesson and related topics: englishladder.com/grammar-concepts/concept-16.html

A practical teaching sequence

1. Notice (2 minutes)

Ask learners to explain the differences between the comparison examples before reading the rules. Use their answers to identify the point that needs attention.

2. Explain and check (4 minutes)

Read the short explanation together. Keep its qualifications: a common pattern is not necessarily a rule for every context. Ask learners to give a counterexample where the lesson mentions an exception.

3. Apply (5 minutes)

Write one recent event and one recent habit or state.

Have learners work alone, then compare with a partner. Ask the partner to restate the intended meaning before suggesting a correction.

4. Review (3 minutes)

Use the answer explanations to review the three checks. Accept natural alternatives that preserve the intended meaning. Ask each learner to revise one sentence and identify the change.

Extension

Change the person, time, place, or purpose in a comparison example. Ask whether the original pattern still fits and why. Revisit one example in the next lesson.

Feedback criteria

Meaning: the message is understandable. Form: the target pattern fits the context. Transfer: the learner can use it in a fresh example. This short activity is not a proficiency certification.